

The Lighthouse at Marrow Point

Chapter One

Nobody in the village could say when the lighthouse had last been lit. The old keeper had gone away one winter and never come back, and the lamp room had stood dark ever since, a black tooth against the evening sky.

Ada climbed the hill every Sunday anyway. She liked the wind up there, and the way the gulls hung in it without moving. From the top step she could see the whole bay, the fishing boats drawn up on the shingle, and the grey line of the far shore.

On the third Sunday of October she found the door unlocked.

It had never been unlocked before. She stood with her hand on the iron latch for a long moment, listening. Nothing moved inside. The air that came out was cold and smelled of salt and lamp oil, and under that, faintly, of woodsmoke.

Chapter Two

The stairs went round and round, and Ada counted them as she climbed. One hundred and twelve. At the top there was a small round room with windows on every side, and in the middle of it, on a wooden stool, sat a boy about her own age, eating an apple.

He did not seem surprised to see her. He held out the apple, as if she might like a bite, and when she shook her head he shrugged and went on eating.

You are the keeper's daughter, he said. It was not a question.

I am nobody's daughter, said Ada. My father went to sea.

Then you had better sit down, said the boy, because I have a great deal to tell you, and the light must be burning before the tide turns.